Isabelle Borgstedt
COGS Thesis Abstract

My thesis explores what makes us trust a robot, and what happens when that robot cheats? Sixty participants played a competitive game against two robots, one that followed the rules and one that secretly “peeked” at hidden information to gain an advantage. Some participants interacted with robots presented as more robotic, while others encountered robots framed with human names, humanlike voices, and a humanoid base.

The results revealed a fascinating tension between morality and performance. A small group of participants who suspected the unfair behavior before being told actually trusted the cheating robot more and were more likely to choose it as a teammate, suggesting that in competitive settings, competence may outweigh fairness. Once cheating was revealed, many participants still chose to collaborate with the cheating robot to gain the advantage. However, participants did shift their moral judgments, selecting the honest robot as most deserving and the cheating robot as least deserving of advancement to another round. Surprisingly, making the robots seem more human did not significantly change how people reacted to them.

By combining interactive gameplay, embodied robotics, and cognitive science, this project examines how people navigate trust, collaboration, and moral judgments when interacting with artificial agents. As AI becomes increasingly integrated into everyday life, these findings raise important questions about whether humans evaluate robots based on morality, utility, or some complicated mix of both.



